

Debates and role plays

DEBATES AND ROLE PLAYS ARE TYPES OF CONVERSATIONS THAT ARE PREPARED FOR IN ADVANCE.

A prepared conversation is very different from an informal chat with friends. Participants need to think about what they are going to say in advance, and consider how they should react to others.

The big debate

A debate is a formal discussion or argument about a topic. Participants need to express their own opinions confidently, and listen and respond to others.

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◀ 206–297 Writing to analyze or review

◀ 216–217 Writing a script

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Presentation skills

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• A **formal discussion** requires **formal language** so try to use Standard English.

I think Powerman is the best superhero because he has the most superhuman powers. He is **incredibly strong** and can fly at **supersonic speeds**.

Always back up an opinion with evidence.

Acknowledge the opposite point of view before disagreeing with it.

I understand your point. **However**, I think Birdman's lack of superpowers makes him more inspirational, **because** he has had to overcome challenges and learn his skills.

▷ Prepare

Participants need to convey their ideas and opinions. The best way to do this is to research the topic in detail, and consider the different points of view related to it. The most effective discussions will cover as many viewpoints as possible.

◁ Listen and respond

Listening is just as important as talking. Participants should show that they are listening to others by responding appropriately and asking relevant questions. They should either agree with someone and add to the point, or disagree and say why.

So, Melvin, **what do you think?** Maybe you prefer someone else, such as Tigerwoman?

Avoid hostile body language.

▷ Involve others

It's important to involve all the participants in a discussion and to act as a group. Everyone should be allowed to speak, without someone else talking over them. Quieter members of the group may need encouragement to join in.

Coax other participants to join in by asking questions.

◁ Body language

Body language helps participants interact with one another. Nodding in agreement is a simple way to do this. Making eye contact with everyone in the group, especially the speaker, is also effective. If someone folds their arms, it looks as if they don't want to be there.

